

LVP-05 Stein

- Villa type: villa urbana and *mansio*?
- RMO 148.
- Year discovered: 1924
- Researchers: Beckers (?), RMO: Remouchamps 1924-1928
- References: Beckers 1926, Holwerda and Remouchamps 1928, Beckers and Beckers 1940.
- Original field drawings present: no.
- Visible on satellite image: no.

Scenic location

The main building is situated on the west flank of a löss-covered elevated Meuse terrace. The front of the building faces towards the Meuse valley in the west. The secondary building lies directly east of the main building.

History

Another village along which the course of the Juliana canal was planned is Stein. Stein was already known as a fertile place for Roman antiquities. At a place known as the Steenakker, rich Roman graves were found by locals as early as 1914. These finds were bought by the museum. Also, the location of the Roman buildings was already known by then. In 1923-4, Dr. Beckers, a local physician with a keen interest in archaeology, excavated two stone sarcophagi and six graves in the vicinity of the robbed cemetery. On this occasion he also partly excavated the remains of the two buildings described here and another site further to the north. Given the importance of the finds, Beckers had to cooperate with the museum. Excavations were carried out under the direction of Holwerda and Remouchamps in 1925 and 1926. Holwerda excavated the most northern site on a hill top, consisting of a moated settlement with traces of wooden buildings from the Late Iron Age and Roman times. Remouchamps (re)examined the two buildings, but his task was extremely difficult since the excavation trenches were still open and extremely deep. Remouchamps also found three substantial stone foundation blocks and walls of what he interpreted as a gate, lying some 240 meters north of the buildings. Traces of half-buried huts from the Late Roman era were also found here. Publication followed in 1928. In 1958 a third stone sarcophagus was found during construction work close by the location of the first two, in the by-then-constructed Heerestraat.

Most of the finds remained in the Beckers' collection in Limburg and the museum of antiquities in Maastricht. One sarcophagus with grave goods can be still seen in the Museum for Burial Culture in Stein. Only a small part of the finds ended up at the RMO.

Main building

The fieldwork at Stein was also carried out with trenches. The layout of large building was unlike other rural Limburg villas. The building measured approximately 30 × 48 m and

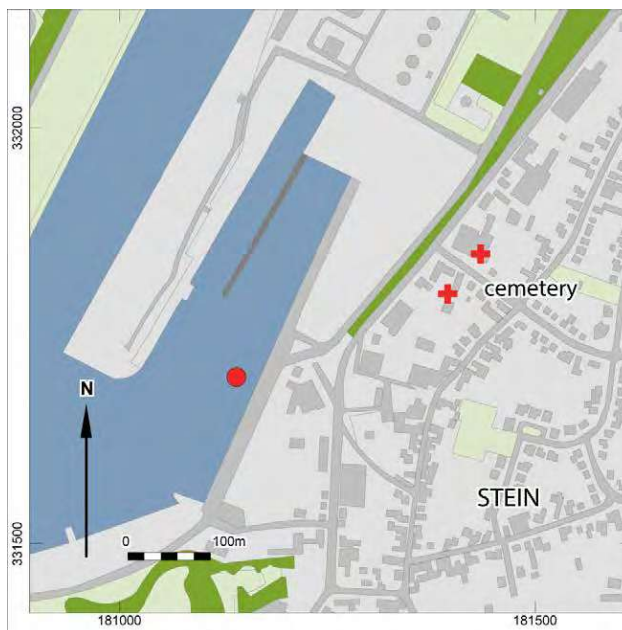


Fig. 14 Locations of sites at Stein.

its layout was entirely symmetrical. The entrance was in the west. Possibly the façade consisted of a 2.5 m reclining portico, with square spaces (pavilions?) on both sides. After entering the building via a small *vestibulum*, again with small rooms at both sides, one would probably have entered a 3 m wide corridor around an inner court of 9 m x 14 m. The corridor would have given access to seven small rooms of approximately 4.5 m x 4.5 m in the north and seven in the south of similar dimensions. These spaces seem mirrored in relation to each other: in the north the easternmost room was somewhat larger, in the south the westernmost. Here, the limited excavation data leaves a lot of room for interpretation; a large part of the foundations had been removed by Beckers when Remouchamps arrived at the excavation. A large room of 8,2 m x 18 m was heated and gave access to an semicircular apse. In one of the small side rooms the remains of the heating system were found. It is therefore quite possible that all the side rooms were heated. No traces of a cellar, nor heating rooms were found. Both the large heated room with the apse and the small side rooms had murals.

Function

Remouchamps pointed to the unusual floor plan and made a proposal that the building was either a peristyle villa with open court or a small inn (*mansio*). This led to much discussion. Byvanck interpreted the building as a 'praetorium' meaning a *mansio* (Byvanck 1947, 43-44). This interpretation persisted for a long time until Jules Bogaers addressed the problem in 1986 (Bogaers 1986). On the one hand, the lack of *prefurniae* and cellars frustrates the interpretation of a peristyle villa (which Bogaers ascribes

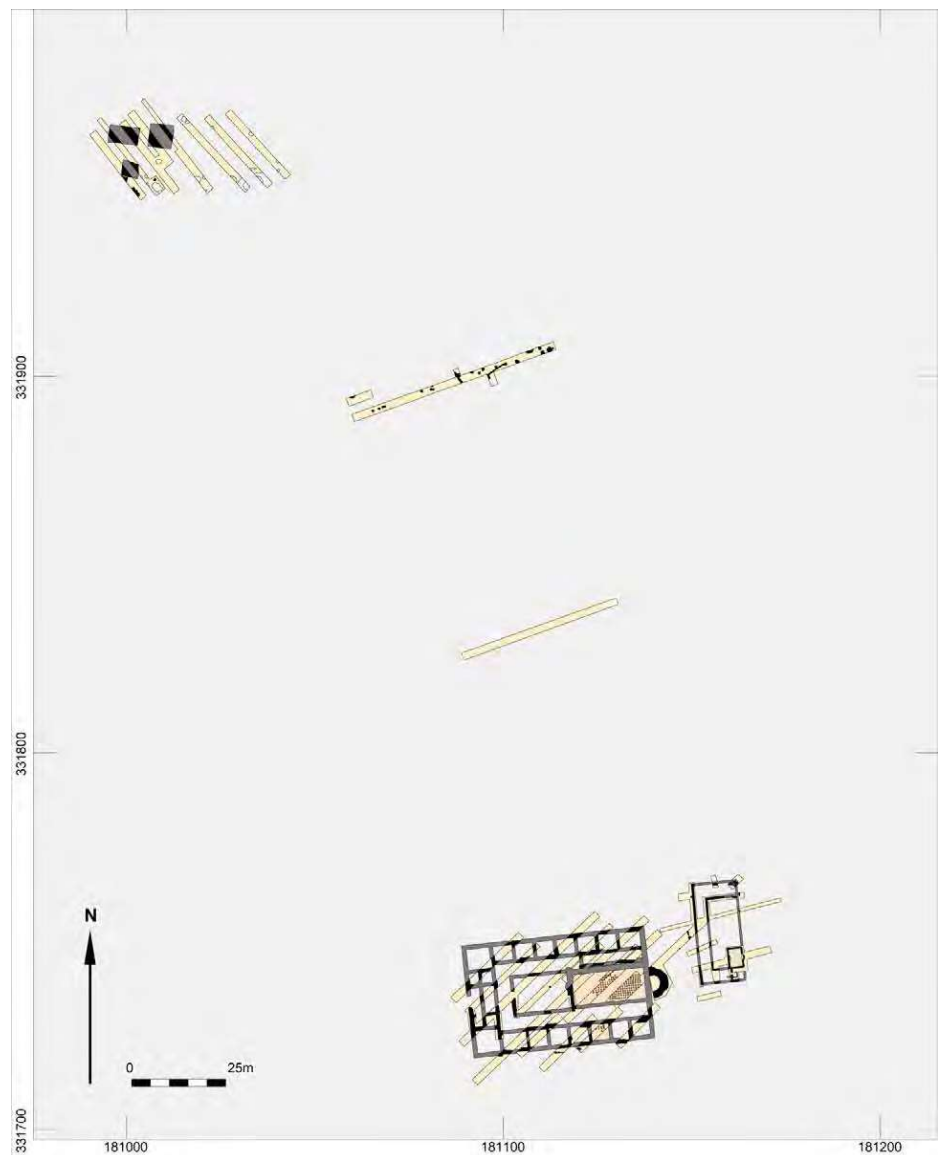


Fig. 15 Excavations by Remouchamps at Stein. After Remouchamps 1928.

to the limited excavation methods), on the other hand no blue prints exist for *mansiones*, nor have apses been attested to them. But most significantly, no main Roman road was situated on the east bank of the Meuse in the vicinity of the complex. To this we can add that both the larger and smaller spaces were plastered and painted with diverse decoration schemes. An interpretation as *mansio* is understandable, however, when compared to the layout of a building in Godmanchester. Here too, we see an inner court surrounded by small spaces, more or less of the same dimensions. Although this building has not yet been published in detail, it is mentioned that the rooms were also decorated with painted plaster (Green and Malin 2017, 99).

Bogaers' arguments for a luxury peristyle-villa are mainly based on the presence of the semicircular apse which connects to a large room, he cites several examples

in Pannonia, of which the villa at Budakalaszi is very convincing (Bogaers 1986, 54, see fig. 17). This layout is typical of *villae* from the end of the 2nd century and in Late Roman times (Hiddink this volume).

Finds

The villa yielded 24 sherds and a fragment of a *tegulae* and a *tubulus* with a hole. These can be dated from the 2nd to the 4th or even early 5th century. Only terra sigillata has been collected. The terra sigillata comprises cups bowls Drag. 37, Drag. 33, plates Drag.18/31 and mortaria Drag. 45. Two fragments are Argonne Ware decorated with roller-stamps, these bowls of type Chenet 320 date to A.D. 320-410.

Furthermore a prismatic glass bottle Isings 50, mural fragments and a coin struck under the reign of Hadrianus are in the RMO collection.